

Is the XP system actually working?

A full trace of insidekhi's XP-and-rank engine — schema, every earn trigger, rank math, the admin grant tool, and one confirmed bug that's currently freezing rank-ups for organic daily-login players.

71 profiles queried 57 points_log rows 5 active ranks 13 XP activities Queried live Postgres, 2026-09-07

1. The verdict, in one table

What was tested end-to-end against the live database, and what came out.

- ✓ Rank thresholds are seeded and active — 5 ranks, 0→3,000 XP, all `is_active = true`.
- ✓ XP → profile total sync trigger works correctly, including the claw-back case — deleting a `points_log` row on review rejection correctly decrements `profiles.points` (verified the trigger body, INSERT/UPDATE/DELETE all handled).
- ✓ Admin manual XP grant tool exists and is role-gated to `admin` / `super_admin`, writes an audit log entry, and does **not** silently bypass activity cooldowns — it runs the same eligibility check as organic awards (see Finding 3 for why that's actually a UI-copy bug, not a feature).
- ✗ Daily login — the single highest-frequency XP action — **never triggers rank recalculation**. A user can cross a rank threshold on login day and stay on their old rank indefinitely. Confirmed in both the web and mobile API routes. See Finding 1.
- ✗ Rank-ups produce zero notification through every server-side award path except one client hook. A ticket check-in, an approved review, or an admin grant that pushes someone to **INSIDER** tells them nothing. See Finding 2.

2. How ranks are actually structured

Live values from the `ranks` table — not seed files, the repo has none. This is the real ladder players climb.

● Explorer		0 XP
● Local		250 XP
● Guide		750 XP
● Influencer		1,500 XP
● INSIDER		3,000 XP

INSIDER is also the only rank with a slot cap — `max_slots = 100` — everything else is uncapped. Bars scaled to 3,000 XP.

Mechanics: rank is *not* a column on the user's profile. It's computed fresh every time `checkAndProcessRankUp()` runs (inside `lib/gamification.ts:133`) by comparing total XP against the threshold list and flipping a `current_rank` flag in a separate `user_ranks` table. There is no cron job and no database trigger doing this — it only runs as the tail end of an XP award. **That's exactly the design that makes Finding 1 possible:** skip the award function, skip the rank check.

Crossing a threshold also silently tries to award a badge named "{Rank} Badge" if one exists in the `badges` table — untested here, but same blast radius as the notification gap in Finding 2.

3. What earns XP today

Every trigger found in the codebase, with live-queried XP values from `xp_activities`. Ordered by value.

ACTION	COOLDOWN	XP	FIRES FROM
Suggest a new place (approved by admin)	Once per submission	50	admin/forms
Complete a challenge	Once per challenge	50	weekly_challenges flow
Scan a location QR code (value set per-QR, not by this row)	Weekly	20–custom	gamification/qr-codes/scan
Attend an event (organizer scans ticket)	Once per ticket	30	tickets/verify
Report incorrect listing/event info (approved)	Once per report	30	admin/forms
Complete profile (name + username + phone)	Once, ever	25	profile update
Invite a friend	Once per invite	25	invitation flow
7-day login streak bonus	Weekly	20	daily-login route
Share a listing link	Daily	10	share flow
Leave a review (once approved by moderation)	Once per listing	10	review moderation
Daily login	Daily	5	daily-login route
Comment on a review	10/day cap	2	reviews/comments
React "helpful" to a review	10/day cap	2	reviews/helpful

Defined in the admin panel but with no code path anywhere that actually awards them: `check_in`, `refer_friend`—as-distinct-from-invite. These exist as UI copy / activity-feed labels only — flag as dead config or finish the wiring.

4. The admin & superadmin XP dashboard

Yes — a superadmin can manually grant XP to any user. It's a real, audited feature.

- **Who can use it:** `role === "admin"` or `"super_admin"`. Rank threshold editing (renaming a rank, moving its XP requirement, setting slot caps) is locked further, to `super_admin` only.
- **How it works:** admin searches a user, picks one of the 13 activities above (or types a custom reason/related-id), submits. It runs through the exact same `awardXP()` function as an organic action — same eligibility check, same rank-up check, same badge check. Nothing about the grant path is special-cased.
- **Paper trail:** every manual grant writes an audit-log row with the admin's id, the target user, the activity, amount, and reason — this is solid and matches good practice for a currency-adjacent feature.
- **Also configurable from the same admin surface:** the XP value and cooldown type of every activity, and the XP reward baked into each location QR code at creation time.

5. Findings

Ranked by how much they undermine the "XP → rank" promise to players.

HIGH Daily login never checks for a rank-up

Both `app/api/gamification/daily-login/route.ts` and its mobile twin insert straight into `points_log` instead of calling `awardXP()`. That skips `checkAndProcessRankUp()` entirely. Daily login is the highest-frequency action in the whole system — for a player who only ever logs in and never does anything else, **rank is permanently frozen at Explorer no matter how much XP they accumulate**, until some other action (a review, a check-in, an admin grant) happens to fire and catches the rank up retroactively.

`app/api/gamification/daily-login/route.ts:207–218` · `app/api/mobile/v1/gamification/daily-login/route.ts:235`

HIGH Rank-ups are silent everywhere except one client hook

`createNotification()` — the shared notification/push/email dispatcher used by reviews, organizer alerts, and segments — is never called from the gamification engine. The only "you ranked up!" moment in the entire app is a client-side toast inside `useXPAward.ts`, which only fires for components that call the generic `/api/xp/award` endpoint directly. A rank-up from a ticket check-in, an approved review, an admin grant, or a QR scan produces no toast, no push, no email, no in-app notification. The reward is invisible unless the player happens to check their own profile.

`lib/gamification.ts` (no notification call in `checkAndProcessRankUp()`) · `hooks/useXPAward.ts:59–69`

MEDIUM Manual XP grant UI claims a cooldown bypass it doesn't have

The admin panel copy says "Manual XP awards bypass cooldown checks for one-time/special cases." The code doesn't do that — it calls the identical `awardXP()` path, so trying to manually re-grant a "once" activity (e.g. Complete Profile) to a user who already has it logged will be rejected with "Activity already claimed," same as a self-serve attempt. Either fix the copy, or add the bypass the copy promises — right now a superadmin trying to hand-fix a stuck player's XP for a support ticket will hit the same wall the player did.

`components/admin/gamification/ManualXPAward.tsx:382–384` · `app/api/admin/gamification/manual-xp/route.ts:83`

MEDIUM No committed schema for the gamification tables

`ranks`, `xp_activities`, `points_log`, `user_ranks`, and the sync trigger that keeps `profiles.points` in sync all exist and work correctly in the live database, but none of them are defined in the repo's tracked SQL migrations. If this environment is ever rebuilt from migrations alone, the entire XP system — including the current rank thresholds — has to be manually reconstructed from memory. Worth exporting the current schema and trigger definitions into a migration file as a one-time backfill.

`sql/migrations/` · live objects confirmed via `pg_trigger` / `information_schema`, not present in any tracked `.sql` file

LOW Legacy `points_log` rows use free-text reasons instead of activity slugs

A prior version of the ticket check-in route wrote rows like "Attended event: Test Event" and "Daily login reward" instead of the canonical slug (`attend_event`, `daily_login`). This has already been fixed going forward — current code uses canonical slugs — but the old rows remain in `points_log`, so any historical reporting or admin-dashboard aggregation keyed on `reason = activity_slug` will undercount those legacy events. Not actively harmful, just a data-quality footnote for whoever builds the XP analytics view.

`points_log.reason` (historical rows) · `app/api/tickets/verify/route.ts:256–262` (comment documents the fix)

6. Weighting: what should give more XP

Current values are flat and mostly ungraded by effort. A four-tier scale gives headroom and makes big actions feel big.

Keep current: daily login

Micro · 5

Correctly the floor value. Fine as-is once Finding 1 is fixed.

Keep current: review reactions/comments

Micro · 2

Correctly gated by a daily cap — prevents farming via comment spam.

Raise: leave a review

Small · 10→20

Writing a real review is meaningfully more effort than reacting to one; the two-comments-equal-one-review ratio undervalues it.

New: add photos to a review

Micro · 5/photo, cap 3

Photo reviews are the highest-value content type for a discovery platform — currently worth nothing extra.

New: first review of a brand-new listing

Medium · 40

Rewards exploring undiscovered places specifically — reinforces "Explorer/Local" rank identity rather than generic review volume.

Keep current: attend event / suggest place / report info

Small · 30/50

Right tier already — real-world verified actions, appropriately above passive engagement.

New: organizer hosts a sold-out or 4.5★+ rated event

Medium · 75

Currently organizers earn nothing from the XP system at all — no incentive loop for the supply side of the platform.

New: referral converts (friend completes profile)

Medium · 60

`invite_friend` exists but should pay out on the invitee's activation, not the invite being sent — sending costs nothing and is easy to spam.

New: monthly streak (30 consecutive days)

Large · 150

The 7-day streak bonus has no bigger sibling — a monthly milestone gives long-term players something to chase beyond rank alone.

New: complete a themed "trail" (visit 5 QR locations in one category)

Large · 100

Turns the existing QR/location system into a designed collection mechanic instead of independent one-off scans — strong INSIDER-rank hook.

New: verified local guide badge (10 approved reviews across distinct listings)

Large · 200, one-time

A capstone achievement gating toward Guide/Influencer rank — currently there's no "big" XP moment between the ~50-point actions and the 3,000-XP INSIDER ceiling.

Audit method: static trace of `lib/gamification.ts`, every `awardXP()` / `points_log` call site, and the admin gamification routes, cross-checked against live queries against the production Postgres instance — actual rank thresholds, activity values, trigger definitions, and a sampled user's XP-vs-rank state. No code was changed.